

County Administration Workshop: May 5, 2026

1:30 p.m. – Board of Commissioners Conference Room

Attending: Commissioners Ron Smith; Colene Martin; Gary Richardson; and Kassie Austin, Recorder

Chair Ron Smith called the meeting to order at 1:30 p.m.

OPEN SESSION

1. Declaration of Potential Conflicts of Interest

The board declared there are no potential conflicts of interest.

2. Department Business

a. Public Health

1. Approve the Grant Request so it can be submitted for consideration to the Solid Waste Agency

Michelle Shaw presented a proposed grant request prepared by Public Health Director Janet Jones for submission to the Solid Waste Agency. Shaw explained that the funding would assist the County in reestablishing and supporting solid waste abatement activities and program operations.

Discussion was held regarding the proposed funding amount of \$155,000 and whether the request represented an annual allocation or a total amount distributed over a three-year period. Commissioners expressed concern that the language within the application materials lacked clarity regarding the duration and structure of the funding. Finance Director Ruth Nelson noted that in prior years the County had received approximately \$155,000 annually through similar funding arrangements.

Commissioners discussed the importance of obtaining clarification from the Solid Waste Agency while still moving the request forward to avoid delays in restoring the County's solid waste abatement program. *Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve submission of the grant request with clarification requested regarding whether the \$155,000 amount represented annual funding or total funding over a three-year period. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.*

Prior to moving to the next agenda item, discussion occurred regarding a pending personnel action associated with the solid waste program. Michelle Shaw explained that approval would be needed to move forward with a personnel action involving a returning solid waste specialist lead position. Commissioners discussed the timing relative to the supplemental budget process and expressed support for proceeding with the personnel action once procedural requirements were satisfied.

b. Human Resources

1. Discuss Current Employee Retiring from PERS. Approval needed from the Board. Josephine County Personnel Policy Article 4, C.2.B

Tamra Martin, Recreation Director, presented a request for approval to allow a retiring PERS employee to return temporarily to County employment on a part-time basis. Martin explained that the employee currently serves as the department's only CDL-qualified operator and possesses significant institutional knowledge necessary to complete the White Horse renovation project.

Martin stated that the proposal would allow the employee to return on a temporary, part-time schedule of approximately 24 hours per week, primarily to complete remaining project work through the grant deadline at the end of August. She explained that the position was budgeted and intended solely as a temporary transition measure.

Discussion occurred regarding the state's allowance for retired PERS employees to return to work under limited circumstances, including both the benefits and potential concerns associated with such arrangements. Commissioners noted that the temporary nature of the assignment and the specialized expertise involved made the proposal appropriate under the circumstances presented.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve bringing back the temporary project position associated with the retiring PERS employee. Commissioner Richardson seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

2. Ogletree Invoice in the amount of \$31,446.00

Michelle Shaw presented an invoice from Ogletree Deakins, the County's labor and employment legal services provider, in the amount of \$31,446.00 dated April 24, 2026. Shaw explained that the invoice related to labor and employment legal matters handled on behalf of the County.

Commissioners acknowledged the invoice as an obligation requiring payment.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve payment of the Ogletree Deakins invoice. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

3. BOARD BUSINESS

a. Resolution No. 2026-009; In the Matter of the Josephine County Board of Commissioners Affirming Tobacco Retail Enforcement as the Primary Strategy to Prevent Youth Access to Tobacco and Nicotine Products and to Protect Adult Consumer Choice

This matter was tabled.

b. Resolution No. 2026-010; In the Matter of the Termination of the Budget Committee

This matter was tabled.

c. Resolution No. 2026-011; In the Matter of Appointments to the Budget Committee

The Board approved without objection.

d. Josephine County Advisory Committee Applications

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to reappoint Jeffrey A. Mundell to the Josephine County Rural Planning Commission. Commissioner Martin seconded the motion. Upon roll call; Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

4. OTHER

Commissioner Martin explained that she has reached out to Aurthur O'Hare, and asked the board if the board is interested in doing a contract with Mr. O'Hare for the Interim Finance Director.

5. ADDITIONAL SUBJECT MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS/ANNOUNCEMENTS:

Chair Ron Smith, called for executive session at 1:47 p.m.

Additional Attendees: Arthur O'hare, Tamra Martin, Chrissy Ewald, Michelle Shaw, Ruth Nelson

6. Executive Session

a. Human Resources

1. Personnel Requisitions

a. Finance – Finance Director, Refill Vacating Position, Vacating May 2026 – ORS

192.660(2)(a)

Discussion was held regarding the upcoming vacancy in the Finance Director position due to the announced retirement of Finance Director Ruth Nelson. Commissioners discussed updating the Finance Director job description, noting that portions of the position description had not been revised since 2018. Commissioner Martin requested that the recruitment process include a panel interview structure involving multiple participants to assist with evaluating candidates. Commissioner Richardson additionally requested an expanded background review process for applicants being considered for the position. The Board discussed the urgency associated with maintaining continuity during the ongoing County budget process and the importance of ensuring experienced oversight during the transition period. Direction was provided to staff to continue moving forward with recruitment planning and associated hiring procedures.

b. Parks – Temporary Project Ranger, Add Position - ORS 192.660(2)(a)

Tamra Martin, Recreation Director, discussed the need for a temporary project ranger position associated with ongoing Parks Department operational projects and grant-related work. Discussion focused on staffing needs necessary to complete current projects and maintain operational continuity through the remaining project timeline. The Board received updates and provided direction to staff to proceed with the requested personnel action.

2. Personnel Actions

a. Emergency Management – Interim Emergency Management Director – New Hire – ORS 192.660(2)(a)

Michelle Shaw advised the Board that a candidate had been selected for the Interim Emergency Management Director position. Discussion occurred regarding onboarding logistics, operational continuity, and travel-related expenses associated

with the candidate. Commissioner Martin expressed support for approving travel expenses associated with the position transition process, including discussion of an estimated travel allocation of approximately \$7,500.

The Board received updates, held discussion, and directed staff to continue moving forward with the hiring process.

b. Finance – Finance Director – FTE Change – ORS 192.660(2)(a)

Discussion was held regarding temporary staffing support within the Finance Department during the transition period following Ruth Nelson's departure. Ms. Nelson indicated willingness to remain available on a limited basis during evenings and weekends to assist with continuity and transition needs. Commissioners additionally discussed the timing of Ms. Nelson's scheduled evaluation and potential step increase, which had been due on May 1, 2026.

The Board reviewed operational considerations related to maintaining continuity within the Finance Department and provided direction to staff to continue moving forward with transition planning.

c. Parks – Temporary Project Ranger – Temporary Hire – ORS 192.660(2)(a). Tamra Martin discussed this matter in Open session under Item 2b1.

d. Assessor - Departmental Specialist – Step Increase – ORS 192.660(2)(a)

Discussion occurred regarding a requested step increase for an employee within the Assessor's Office. The Board reviewed staffing considerations and personnel recommendations associated with the request. Direction was provided to staff to continue moving forward with the personnel action.

e. Public Works – Fleet Program Supervisor – New Hire – Potential Hire at Step 3 – ORS 192.660(2)(a)

The Board discussed a proposed new hire for the Public Works Fleet Program Supervisor position, including consideration of placement at Step 3 based on prior supervisory and technical experience. Michelle Shaw advised the Board regarding the applicant's background and qualifications. Commissioners discussed the applicant's work history, supervisory experience, and recruitment timeline, including questions regarding the length of time the position had been posted.

Following discussion, the Board provided direction to staff regarding continuation of the hiring process.

2. To consider the dismissal or discipline of, or to hear complaints or charges against public officer, employee, staff member or individual agent: Airports Manager – ORS 192.660(20)(b)

This matter was tabled.

Additional personnel discussions occurred regarding ongoing staffing transitions, operational continuity, and recruitment planning within multiple County departments. One agenda item was tabled for further discussion at a future meeting

Executive Session adjourned at 2:12 p.m.

8. Open Session Cont'd

Upon returning to open session, Chair Smith summarized that the Board had received updates, held discussions, and provided direction to staff on the Executive Session personnel matters. The Board additionally determined that one agenda item would be tabled until the following week.

Commissioner Martin introduced discussion regarding former Josephine County Finance Director Arthur O'Hare potentially serving in an interim capacity following the upcoming retirement of Finance Director Ruth Nelson on May 19, 2026. Commissioner Martin stated that she had previously worked with O'Hare and believed his prior experience with the County would be beneficial during the transition period and ongoing budget process. Discussion occurred regarding the possibility of structuring the arrangement as an independent contractor agreement, subject to review and preparation by Legal Counsel. Arthur O'Hare addressed the Board and stated that he previously served sixteen years with the County, including ten years as Controller and six years as Finance Director. O'Hare explained that while he was not interested in returning full-time, he would be willing to assist on a part-time basis to support the budget process, provide guidance to finance staff, and assist with continuity during the transition.

Commissioners discussed the importance of maintaining continuity through the budget adoption timeline ending June 30, 2026, and expressed appreciation for both O'Hare's willingness to assist and Ruth Nelson's service to the County. Commissioner Martin additionally stated that she would like O'Hare to participate in the hiring panel process for the permanent Finance Director position.

No formal action was taken during the discussion. Staff was directed to continue working with Legal Counsel regarding contract development and next steps

The meeting adjourned at 2:20 p.m.